

ShiftBoard API: Production Release Runbook

Owner: Platform Team | Doc version 3.2 | Last reviewed: March 2026

Applies to	shiftboard-api (Node.js service)
Who runs it	Release engineer on rotation
Approx. time	35 to 45 minutes, plus 15 minutes post-deploy watch

Purpose

Follow this every time shiftboard-api goes to production. Most of our release incidents in the last year came from a skipped step, not a code bug. If a step fails, stop and post in #releases before continuing. Do not skip steps to hit a deadline.

Before you release

- 1. CI is green on main.** Check the latest pipeline run on main. Never release from a red or cancelled build, even if the failure looks unrelated.
- 2. Version and changelog.** Bump the version in package.json using semver. Add an entry to CHANGELOG.md under the new version number. The version in package.json is what we tag the image with, so they must match.
- 3. Production config is present.** Confirm DATABASE_URL, JWT_SECRET and LOG_LEVEL are set for the target environment. Heads up: the service boots fine without JWT_SECRET, but every login will fail with a 401. We have been burned by this twice.
- 4. Migrations on staging.** Run pending database migrations against staging and make sure they finish cleanly:

```
npm run migrate
```

Verify staging

- 5. Health check.** Call GET /health on staging. It must return 200 *and* report that the database is reachable. A plain 200 is not enough, because the process can be up while the DB connection is dead.
- 6. Smoke tests.** Run the smoke suite against staging. It has to cover the three flows customers use most: logging in, creating a shift, and listing shifts. All three must pass.

```
npm run smoke
```

Build and ship

- 7. Build the image.** Build the Docker image and tag it with the version from package.json. Never ship an image tagged latest.
- 8. Non-root container.** The container must not run as root. Security review will block the release if it does.
- 9. Record the rollback point.** Before deploying, write the currently deployed image tag to releases/PREVIOUS_TAG and commit it. On-call uses this file to roll back at 2 AM, so do not skip it.
- 10. Watch after deploy.** Keep the production dashboard open for 15 minutes after the deploy. If the 5xx rate goes above 2 percent, roll back using the tag from step 9 and post in #releases.

Rolling back

Redeploy the image tag stored in releases/PREVIOUS_TAG. Do not roll back database migrations without talking to the Platform lead first. Open an incident ticket for any rollback, even a short one.

Questions about this runbook go to the Platform Team. If a step here no longer matches how the service works, flag it in #releases so we can update the doc.